

First up is differentiation. The theory of differentiation, according to Murray Bowen, who is considered to be one of the founding fathers of this movement, is the ability to both emotionally connect with others and yet at the same time remain autonomous. To be both together and yet separate. It's the ability to live our own lives *with* but differently to our family and society.

At the heart of differentiation is the struggle each of us faces daily to define ourselves as separate, autonomous individuals from society as a whole. The word struggle is key—because for many of us it's easier to follow the path our parents, our peers and society expects of us. Or to consume in the way advertisers tell us to. The danger for us financially is when we live in a way that goes against our values and the lives we want to design for ourselves just to appease those around us. Which is why it's important to answer the questions I've been asking throughout this chapter to help you determine if you're living based on your values or if you've simply adopted those around you, regardless of whether they're right for you.

If we think about our finances, differentiation is the willingness to reform the boundaries of your Money Environment, even though this might cause conflict and disappointment and go against the expectations of those within your environment. It doesn't mean we have to live separately from those who might be financially hindering us. To link this concept back to Dr Brené Brown's work on boundaries that we looked at earlier, it's about knowing our story, choosing our own brave new ending and setting up 'BIG' boundaries to support that.

The second tool that can help us build a positive Money Environment is self-reliance. 'Self-Reliance', an influential essay first published in 1841 and written by US philosopher Ralph Waldo Emerson, exhorted individuals to avoid conformity and to embrace their own instincts and ideas.

Self-reliance, according to Emerson, contains three main elements. The first involves learning to trust your own judgements. This element is summed up by Emerson's famous exhortation for people to 'trust thyself'. Of course, when it comes to our finances, one of the biggest barriers to self-reliance is that we don't trust ourselves. Many of us know we don't have enough self-control or we wonder how we can trust ourselves if we